

Vignette 8a Language Attitude Surveys

Speaker Evaluation Studies

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In addition to understanding how people use language, sociolinguists often want to understand what people think about the language they use or that other people use. People's beliefs and feelings are related to their linguistic behavior, and feelings about language forms impact people who use those forms. Beliefs and feelings are also interesting in themselves and have practical implications, for example in language policy and planning.

When we study beliefs and feelings about language, we are studying language attitudes and language ideologies. We use a variety of methods to learn about them, including interviews, ethnographic observation, online data mining, surveys, and experiments. Many of these techniques are discussed elsewhere in this book; in this vignette, I focus on a particular technique for learning about language attitudes, called speaker evaluation studies (Giles & Billings, 2004).

In speaker evaluation studies, recordings are played to listeners, who then share opinions about the voices they heard. The recordings differ in specific ways, for example one in Spanish and one in English, or in two different regional accents. With this setup, listener reactions can (hopefully) be taken to indicate something about how the listeners view the language forms in question. Although speaker evaluation studies are not the only way to learn about people's language attitudes, they are a popular one, and there are a number of tricks to doing them well. Having run a few of these myself, I will walk through a few key issues to consider in planning an experiment of this kind.

Stimuli Are the Heart of Your Experiment

All of the conclusions you draw from your experiment are based on reactions to the actual stimuli to which your participants are exposed, not to whatever categories they are intended to represent. This means that the choices you make in selecting or creating your stimuli are the most important choices in your experimental design. Four important considerations are reviewed here.

1 *Creating guises.* In verbal guise studies (Cooper, 1974, 1975), reactions to people who speak different languages or speak with different accents are compared. This technique is handy if you are comparing a large number of varieties, or varieties that are not spoken in the same areas. Research using this technique has been used to find out that teens in Denmark think more highly of other teens who use "Low Copenhagen" linguistic features, even though when asked directly they say that "High Copenhagen" is a better way to speak (Kristiansen & Jørgensen, 2005).

When using different speakers, you run the risk that the speakers are driving the results. If you choose more friendly or articulate speakers for one variety, that characteristic may come through in voice quality, prosody, or other characteristics irrelevant to your study. You may think that everyone in your study prefers that variety, when it is

really the speaker(s) they like. To counteract that danger, Lambert, Hodgson, Gardner, and Fillenbaum (1960) developed the matched guise technique in which a single speaker produces both (or all) guises, unbeknownst to the listeners. This is not a perfect solution, since people may have different “personalities” across their different languages or accents, but it may reduce the variability.

Recently, technology such as the free software Praat (Boersma & Weenink, 2011) has allowed us to directly manipulate the acoustic stream, changing formant structures (Plichta & Preston, 2005) or splicing acoustic material (Campbell-Kibler, 2008; Labov et al., 2006). These techniques can yield stimuli that differ only in the precise linguistic characteristics we are interested in. While this control is very useful, such manipulation can risk creating unnatural stimuli that either strike the ear as audibly odd or, perhaps more dangerously, contain subtle anomalies that may lead listeners astray. Whether the benefits or drawbacks are greater depends on the project in question.

2 *Read, acted, or spontaneous?* Most studies prefer speech that is read aloud, because of the control it gives over the word, the content, and the linguistic environments of variables. Some researchers (including me) think that using spontaneous speech where possible makes for a more natural evaluation task. As a compromise, sometimes it is possible to prompt your speakers to tell a well-known story (e.g., a fairy tale or legend) to control content while collecting spontaneous speech. It is also sometimes possible to give speakers short passages and encourage them to memorize the material, so that they are reciting rather than reading it.

3 *Message content.* Whether linguists like it or not, what we think of someone depends a lot on what they say, not just how they say it. Sometimes it’s a simple case of evaluating what someone says directly. In one of my stimuli, the speaker was often described as lazy because he’s talking about how much work it is to attend a movie. People thought he was lazy because he was saying things that sounded lazy! Sometimes it can be more complex, when content interacts with linguistic forms. Another speaker in that same study talks about other people in an ambiguous way; from the clips, you can’t tell whether she likes them or not. When she uses forms like *workin’* instead of *working*, some listeners think she is being condescending while others think she’s compassionate (Campbell-Kibler, 2008). The content is interacting with the language to produce different impressions. These kinds of interactions can be much harder to anticipate and prepare for.

How to solve this problem? One important thing to note is that there’s no such thing as socially neutral content. Even when content doesn’t obviously require a particular interpretation or identity, small cues are always going to affect how listeners perceive a speaker. Instead of trying to find neutral content, it is more useful to think about the potential effect of the particular content you have, pilot your stimuli, and, as noted below, have more than one example.

4 *Have more than one example.* The best way to avoid problems associated with message content and irrelevant (to you) speaker characteristics is to make sure that your study design doesn’t rest entirely on the quirks of a single recording. Have more than one sample representing each category you’re studying. For a study that compared *-in* and *-ing* guises in speakers of different genders and regions, I made sure I had two speakers of each type (e.g., male Californians) and four example utterances from each speaker. If possible, more than two speakers would be even better.

Tasks and Context

Once you have stimuli that represent the language forms of interest, you need a set of participants to respond to them and something for those participants to do that will

reflect their impressions of the stimuli. This section touches on three important decisions to be made in this part of the process.

1 *Choosing tasks.* The most common task for speaker evaluation studies is rating the speakers on a set of qualities (Zahn & Hopper, 1985), but this is not the only thing you can have people do. Some of the most interesting studies have used real tasks such as choosing to fill out a questionnaire at a theater (Bourhis & Giles, 1976; Kristiansen & Giles, 1992) or choosing whether to return a letter or email that has been misaddressed (Bushman & Bonacci, 2004; Milgram, 1977). In these highly realistic studies, participants may not even be aware that they have participated in a study, so little does the task impinge on their lives. More explicit evaluation tasks may be made more realistic by providing a framework of evaluation, as when asking a teacher to evaluate schoolchildren (Williams et al., 1976).

2 *Pilot testing.* One handy technique for improving data quality is to pilot test the tasks and stimuli with participants sampled from the same population as the main study. Pilot testing can involve open-ended questioning—I used focus groups—to get a sense of how your participants perceive the stimuli and what concepts and terms appear naturally as they discuss them. Pilot testing can also be used to check the quality of your stimuli; for example, whether manipulated stimuli sound natural or whether pictures convey the social qualities intended. A related technique called cognitive interviewing (Willis, 2005) involves asking participants to answer the questions, then walk you through their reasoning, to make sure your questions are clearly worded.

3 *Choosing words.* Even within the traditional approach of rating along personal dimensions, a task may be more or less natural for a participant. It is often a good idea to conduct pilot studies to ascertain what qualities your intended population is most concerned with and what terms its members use to discuss them. It is possible that I may find results when asking pre-teens about the perceived “loquaciousness” of a set of speakers, but it is almost certain those results will be more difficult to interpret than if I’d piloted and discovered that (1) they didn’t know what the word meant, and (2) they don’t really care about the quality referred to, so they tend not to evaluate people on it. Such piloting can even drive research questions, as when Giles, Smith, Browne, Whiteman, and Williams (1980) talked to people in the late 1970s and discovered that both men and women reported that one of the first things they assessed about a woman whose acquaintance they were making was whether she was affiliated with the feminist movement.

Speaker evaluation experiments can be a great tool for assessing language attitudes by providing a task that feels natural to participants and, if done well, conceals the specifics of your research question. Careful selection of your stimuli and your tasks makes all the difference in building a study that will yield interesting and understandable results.

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